



being separated – culturally and regulatorily – from gambling-adjacent play. That matters more than people realise. When eSports isn't constantly forced to explain “we're not betting,” it can finally talk about training, leagues, teams, coaching, media rights, college circuits, sponsorships, and career paths.

The opportunity is huge: India already has the audience, the players, and the streaming culture. What it needs is structure and legitimacy. A cleaner separation from RMG improves sponsor comfort, investor confidence, and mainstream acceptance. Translation: more tournaments that feel like sport, not a promo stunt.

The big watch-out for 2026 is whether the ecosystem produces repeatable success stories – players and teams

that win consistently, leagues that run on time and pay on time, and brands that sponsor for the long term instead of chasing short-term hype. If that happens, eSports becomes a real industry. If it doesn't, it risks drifting back into the shadow of the loudest, most controversial parts of “online gaming.”

XR devices explode (finally)

XR – virtual reality, augmented reality, mixed reality, the whole alphabet soup – has been “the next big thing” for so long that it started sounding like a threat. But 2026 is genuinely different: devices are lighter, clearer, and less demo-ish; content is better; and, crucially, smart glasses are becoming less weird.

Meta and others have kept pushing the consumer end of the market,

combining headsets with glasses-style wearables and sprinkling AI into the experience. The interesting shift is that XR is no longer only about escapist gaming. It's also about utility: navigation, hands-free capture, quick queries, translation, and “just enough” overlays to be helpful without turning life into a sci-fi movie.

And then comes the India plot twist: local brands moving from “retail at scale” to “tech at scale.” When a mainstream eyewear player talks about smart glasses, it matters because distribution and affordability are usually what stop XR from becoming truly mainstream here. If smart glasses look like normal frames, work with Indian habits (payments, navigation, language), and don't cost a kidney, they can cross the chasm faster than bulky headsets ever could.

Will XR become universal in 2026? Not overnight. But the category is finally moving from “early adopter theatre” to “I can see why I'd use this” – and that's how mainstream trends begin.

Screen-less AI devices and rise of do-it-for-me tech

If 2023–24 was about chatbots, and 2025 was about AI everywhere, then 2026 is about AI that actually does things – and sometimes does them without living inside a traditional screen.

The big shift is agentic behaviour: software that doesn't just answer questions, but executes tasks. Your tools are slowly becoming mini assistants that can pull data, create drafts, schedule meetings, summarise threads, handle follow-ups, and stitch together actions across apps. The goal isn't “wow, it can write poetry.” It's “wow, it handled the boring part of my day.”

This is also where screen-less or screen-light devices start making sense. If the interface is voice, a button, or a small glanceable display, the value comes from intent: tell it what you want, let it do the app-hopping. For India, this matters because we're mobile-first, often multilingual, and frequently doing life admin on small screens. If an assistant

